ROME, ITALY

Galleria Borghese: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which physical contact carries much of the story.



Bernini's Proserpina twists away from the arms lifting her. Raphael's bearers coordinate their movements around the weight of the dead Christ. In both works, the relation between bodies explains the action before every participant has been named. Looking at contact offers an immediate route into subjects that can otherwise arrive burdened with mythology or doctrine.

The selection also includes portraits, a concert and figures assuming classical roles. Here the body's task may be to present rather than struggle. Keep the individual objects distinct: the *Apollo and Daphne* below is Dosso Dossi's painting, not Bernini's sculpture. Shared titles and familiar stories can conceal important differences in medium, episode and point of view.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/galleria-borghese

The selection · 20

1. Apollo and Daphne
   Dosso Dossi · 1524
2. The Abduction of Proserpina
   Gian Lorenzo Bernini · 1621-1622
3. Sacred and Profane Love
   Titian · 1515–1516
4. Boy with a Basket of Fruit
   Caravaggio · 1593
5. Sick Bacchus
   Caravaggio · 1593
6. Madonna of the Palafrenieri
   Caravaggio · 1606
7. Marcello Sacchetti
   Pietro da Cortona · c. 1626
8. Saint Jerome Writing
   Caravaggio · c. 1606
9. Minerva Dressing
   Lavinia Fontana · 1613
10. Cupid and Psyche
    Jacopo Zucchi · 1589
11. The Deposition
    Raphael · 1507
12. Saint John the Baptist
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13. Self-Portrait as a Mature Man
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14. Self-Portrait as a Young Man
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17. Saint John the Baptist
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18. Madonna and Child with the Infant Saint John
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19. Adoration of the Child
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20. David with the Head of Goliath
    Orazio Gentileschi · 1610

01 / 20

Apollo and Daphne

Dosso Dossi

1524 · Galleria Borghese



Dosso Dossi. Apollo and Daphne. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Dosso Dossi places the music-making Apollo close to the viewer, while the pursuit involving Daphne unfolds farther back. The painting separates activities that its title may lead us to expect in one immediate encounter. Attention has to travel between foreground performance and distant narrative. The landscape is part of that separation, not merely scenery behind a single action.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Abduction of Proserpina

Gian Lorenzo Bernini

1621-1622 · Galleria Borghese



Gian Lorenzo Bernini. The Rape of Proserpina. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Pluto's upward grip meets Proserpina's twisting resistance and her hand against his face. Bernini makes opposing forces occupy one sculptural group. The apparent indentation of the thigh under his fingers adds another contradiction: hard marble describes yielding flesh. Technical virtuosity should not eclipse the subject's coercion; the material effect makes the physical pressure more legible.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Sacred and Profane Love

Titian

1515–1516 · Oil on canvas · Galleria Borghese



Titian. Sacred and Profane Love. Image credit: Titian; Source credit: Galleria Borghese. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Similar faces and different states of dress connect the two women while setting them apart. Between them, Cupid's hand enters the water. The familiar title does not close the interpretative problem: the museum discusses a range of readings and favours a marital context. Begin with the pairing before assigning one figure a simple moral superiority over the other.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 147

04 / 20

Boy with a Basket of Fruit

Caravaggio

1593 · Galleria Borghese



Caravaggio. Boy with a Basket of Fruit. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The basket reaches forward, bringing fruit, leaves and face into a shared claim on attention. Caravaggio does not leave still life as a minor accessory to a portrait. The young man's turned body and slipping shirt establish an encounter in which the held objects occupy much of the available space between figure and viewer.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Sick Bacchus

Caravaggio

1593 · Galleria Borghese



Caravaggio. Young Sick Bacchus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Ivy and grapes identify a classical role carried by an unidealised young body. The turn over the bare shoulder gives the figure a constrained relation to the table and fruit. Pale flesh is available for observation, but a painted appearance cannot establish a medical diagnosis. The familiar title should not be allowed to substitute for evidence about illness.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Madonna of the Palafrenieri

Caravaggio

1606 · Oil on canvas · Galleria Borghese



Madonna and Child with St. Anne. WikiArt; Caravaggio. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Mary steadies the child as a small foot presses against the serpent; the older woman watches. Caravaggio makes the religious action depend on shared balance and pressure. Three generations occupy the dark setting, distinguished by strong light and bodily scale. The smallest figure carries the decisive action while remaining physically dependent on support.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Marcello Sacchetti

Pietro da Cortona

c. 1626 · Oil on canvas · Galleria Borghese



Pietro da Cortona. Marcello Sacchetti. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pietro-da-cortona/marcello-sacchetti · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

White lace interrupts the black clothing at collar and cuff, directing attention towards face and hand. An architectural support gives the standing figure a formal setting. Pietro da Cortona allows public presentation to emerge through controlled bearing and material distinction. The portrait's display is distributed across dress and pose rather than concentrated in an overtly dramatic gesture.

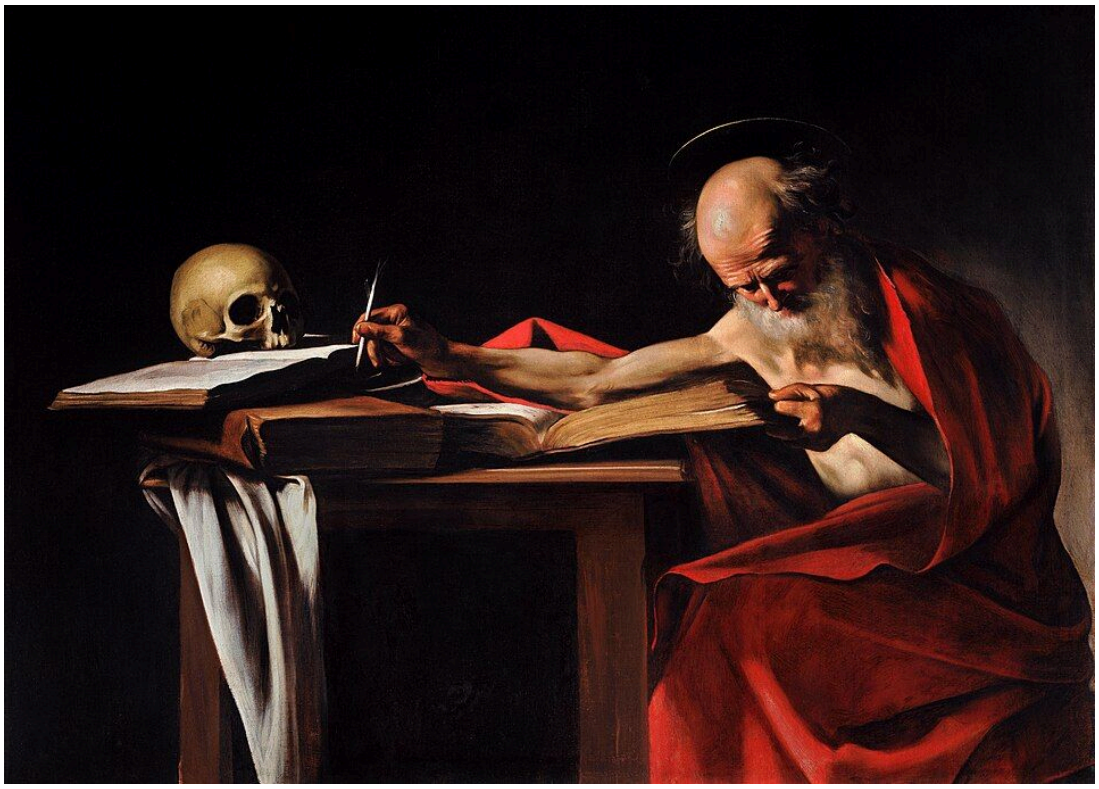
Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Saint Jerome Writing

Caravaggio

c. 1606 · Oil on canvas · Galleria Borghese



Caravaggio. Saint Jerome. Image credit: Caravaggio; Source credit: Self-scanned. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The bare arm stretches across the table towards the work, creating a long illuminated connection through the dark setting. At the other end, the skull introduces mortality into the same working space. Caravaggio does not separate intellectual labour from the vulnerable body performing it. Writing is made visible as an effort sustained by an ageing person.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 056

09 / 20

Minerva Dressing

Lavinia Fontana

1613 · Galleria Borghese



Lavinia Fontana. Minerva Dressing. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Armour and helmet identify Minerva even when they are not being worn. Lavinia Fontana presents the goddess in an interval of dressing, with the turned body reaching towards clothing. Role and costume are briefly separated. The surrounding objects preserve the mythological identity while the action reveals the practical transition into its familiar appearance.

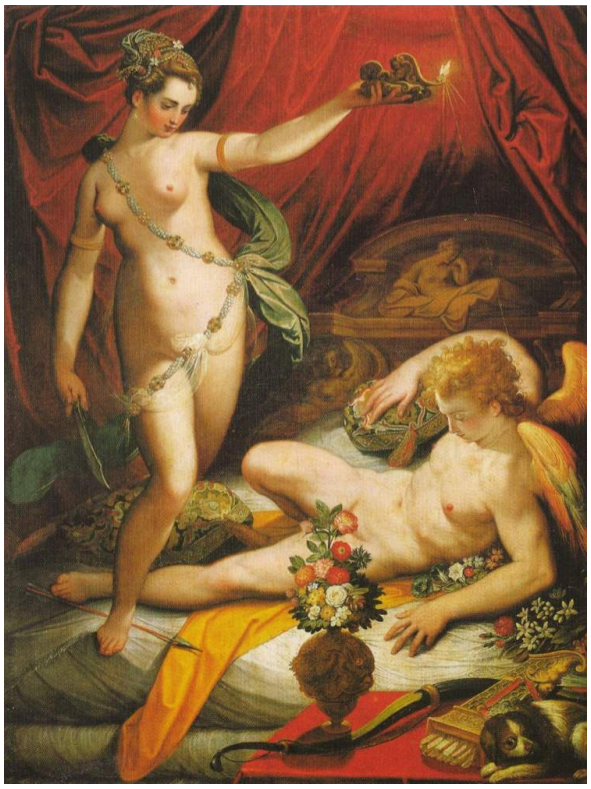
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Cupid and Psyche

Jacopo Zucchi

1589 · Galleria Borghese



Jacopo Zucchi. Amor and Psyche. Image credit: Jacopo Zucchi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The raised lamp makes looking the decisive action. Psyche approaches the sleeping Cupid through a crowded setting of flowers, fabric and pale bodies. Zucchi gives illumination a narrative function: it permits a discovery while exposing the act that produces it. The light belongs to someone's decision inside the scene rather than arriving as an unexplained theatrical effect.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 010

11 / 20

The Deposition

Raphael

1507 · Oil on panel · Galleria Borghese



Raphael. Deposition (The Carrying of the Dead Christ to the Sepulchre). Image credit: Raphael; Source credit: aiwaz.net. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The bearers must coordinate opposing steps around Christ's weight. Nearby, a collapsing mourner creates another need for support. Raphael joins these actions within a group whose grief is inseparable from bodily effort. The dead body and the faltering living figure require different responses, giving the composition more than one centre of physical dependence.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 369

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Saint John the Baptist

Bronzino

c. 1560 · Galleria Borghese



Bronzino. Saint John the Baptist. Image credit: Bronzino. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Bronzino twists the torso across the rocky seat while the pointing arm establishes another direction. Blue cloth distinguishes the exposed body without resolving its complicated pose. The saint is presented through bodily arrangement rather than a fully narrated episode. Following the different axes of arm and torso explains the figure's activity before the gesture's religious significance is added.

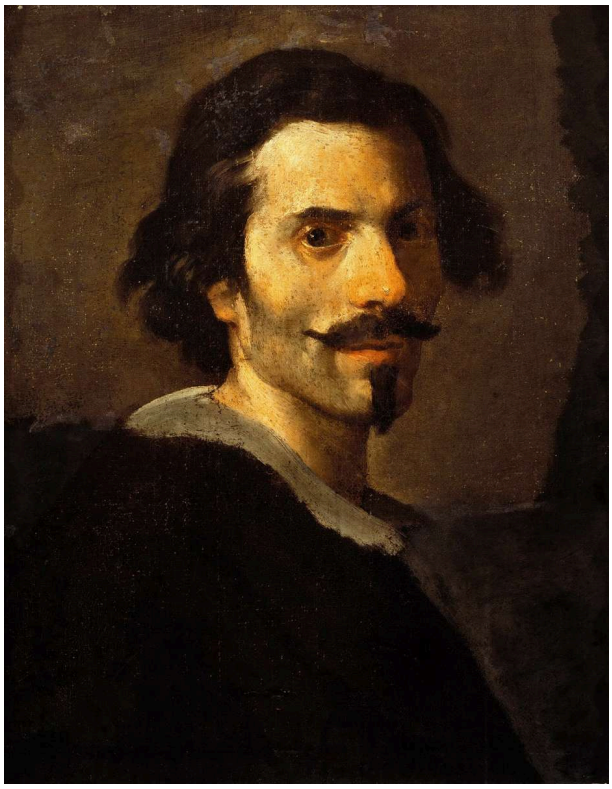
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 444

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Self-Portrait as a Mature Man

Gian Lorenzo Bernini

c. 1635–1640 · Galleria Borghese



Gian Lorenzo Bernini. Self Portrait of Gianlorenzo Bernini as a Mature Man (1638-40). Image credit: Gian Lorenzo Bernini. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Light gathers around Bernini's eyes and cheek, while a small white collar interrupts the dark clothing. The surrounding marks are economical enough to leave the face in command. Compared with his sculptural groups, this painted self-presentation requires little overt action. Its immediacy is constructed through selective emphasis rather than a narrative event.

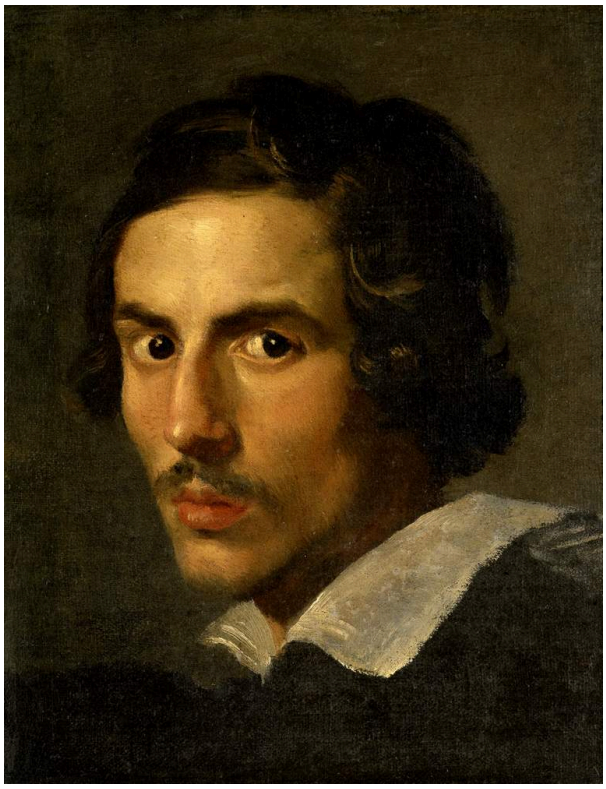
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 545

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Self-Portrait as a Young Man

Gian Lorenzo Bernini

1623 · Galleria Borghese



Gian Lorenzo Bernini. Self Portrait of Gianlorenzo Bernini as young man (1623). Image credit: Gian Lorenzo Bernini. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The turned head directs attention differently from the body beneath its broad collar. Dark hair and shadow frame the eyes, making their orientation conspicuous. Comparing the two Bernini self-portraits can begin with these modest changes of pose and illumination. There is no need to read a complete account of youth or maturity into either expression.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 554

15 / 20

The Taking of Christ

Dirck van Baburen

c. 1619 · Galleria Borghese



Dirck van Baburen. The Capture of Jesus Christ. Image credit: Dirck van Baburen. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The narrow dark space makes faces and armour seem to obstruct one another. Baburen selects parts of the arrest through reflected light while leaving other contacts difficult to disentangle. The lack of room is consequential. It turns the event into a close bodily encounter rather than allowing a detached view of neatly separated participants.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Concert

Gerard van Honthorst

1626–1630 · Galleria Borghese



Gerard van Honthorst. The Concert. Image credit: Gerard van Honthorst. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Open music gives the crowded company a shared reference point, but their attention moves between page and companions. Honthorst distinguishes the tasks of playing, reading and listening inside the compact group. Feathered hats extend its silhouette above the table. The concert is visible as coordination among different actions rather than as one repeated musician's pose.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 31

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Saint John the Baptist

Caravaggio

1609–1610 · Oil on canvas · Galleria Borghese



Caravaggio. Saint John the Baptist. Image credit: Caravaggio; Source credit: Self-scanned. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

Caravaggio's seated figure offers a marked contrast with Bronzino's twisting saint. Dropped shoulders and partly extended legs make inactivity conspicuous beside the red cloth and nearby ram. Traditional signs identify John without dictating an energetic prophetic pose. The exposed body and its slack arrangement deserve attention before an emotional explanation is assigned to the young face.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 267

18 / 20

Madonna and Child with the Infant Saint John

Lorenzo di Credi

1488–1490 · Galleria Borghese



Lorenzo di Credi. Virgin and Child with the Infant Saint John the Baptist. Image credit: Lorenzo di Credi. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The circular boundary gathers several directions of attention around Mary's upright figure. Lorenzo di Credi lets the children's differing poses animate that enclosure without breaking the group's closeness. The landscape offers another space behind them. The round format is an active constraint on how bodies and their gestures can fit together.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Adoration of the Child

Fra Bartolomeo

1499 · Galleria Borghese



Fra Bartolomeo. Adoration of the Child. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The child lies low, requiring the adults' bodies to bend towards the ground. Fra Bartolomeo organises their attention into a broad triangular relation inside the circular panel. Ruins and landscape remain behind the group, but the immediate action is a lowering of bodies. The smallest figure determines the others' posture despite occupying little space.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

David with the Head of Goliath

Orazio Gentileschi

1610 · Galleria Borghese



Orazio Gentileschi. David Contemplating the Head of Goliath. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Orazio Gentileschi chooses an interval after the struggle. David looks down towards the severed head, his body now comparatively settled against the dark tree. Pale cloth and limbs keep him distinct without reenacting the battle. The painting presents a result and an act of attention, leaving the preceding violence to be reconstructed from what remains.

Object source · Open artwork

Compare before naming a mood

The two Saint Johns and the two Bernini self-portraits offer especially useful comparisons of posture. Keep artists and object identities attached to their titles. Check current access and displays with the gallery; this selection is not a timed route through its rooms.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

The sections on movement and the disposition of figures offer a starting point for comparing the effort in Raphael’s bearers with the supported, twisting bodies in Bernini’s sculpture.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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